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TEASER

Unwarranted Influence

A Primary-Source Investigation, 1095–2026

Kyle Jimenez

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OVERTURE — On October 20, 1942, the Office of Alien Property Custodian of the United States of America, acting under the authority of the Trading with the Enemy Act of October 6, 1917, as amended, and pursuant to Executive Order 9095 of March 11, 1942, issued Vesting Order Number 248. The order was filed with the

Division of the Federal Register on November 6, 1942, and published the following day at *Federal Register*, Volume 7, page 9097 (November 7, 1942). It ordered the seizure of all property of the Union Banking Corporation, 39 Broadway, New York. The order recites that the Union Banking Corporation was “a national of a designated enemy country

(Germany).” The shares had been held, the order finds, “for the benefit of Members of the Thyssen family, nationals of Germany and/or Hungary.” One of the seven directors of the Union Banking Corporation on October 20, 1942, was Prescott Sheldon Bush. Prescott Bush was elected to the United States Senate in 1952. His son became

President of the United States. His grandson became President of the United States. — On April 1, 1967, the Central Intelligence Agency issued a memorandum to its field stations. It was catalogued as Dispatch 1035-960. Its subject line read “Countering Criticism of the Warren Report.” It directed recipients to “employ propaganda

assets to answer and refute the attacks of the critics" and to "discuss the publicity problem with liaison and friendly elite contacts (especially politicians and editors)." It furnished seven suggested rebuttal themes. One of the themes characterized critics of the Warren Commission as, in the dispatch's own phrase, "conspiracy theorists."

The dispatch was classified SECRET. The dispatch was declassified in 1976 under a Freedom of Information Act request filed by the *New York Times*, case F-76-1183. It is presently held at the National Archives, Record Group 263, CIA Historical Review Program, and is reproduced in full at the CIA Electronic Reading

Room, document 1035-960. — On June 13, 2025, the President of the United States filed Office of Government Ethics Form 278e, the annual financial disclosure required of senior federal officers under the Ethics in Government Act of 1978. On that form, he reported $57,354,228 in income from a cryptocurrency venture

titled World Liberty Financial, LLC, 75 percent of whose net proceeds flow to his family through an entity titled DT Marks DeFi LLC. The filing is on the website of the Office of Government Ethics, oge.gov. On October 28, 2025, Reuters, in an investigation by reporters Stephen Gandel and Hannah Lang titled *Inside the*

***Trump family's global crypto cash machine*, calculated the first-half-2025 total of the President's crypto-related income at approximately $672 million. Neither filing is classified. Both are on the public internet. Both can be read at the URLs printed in the appendix of this book. — Each of the three documents above is the starting**

point of a chapter. The chapters document what followed. The documents speak. The book arranges them. — *A note on method.* Every factual claim in the chapters that follow is sourced to a document, a filing, a court docket, a congressional report, or a peer-reviewed historical work. Citations appear in footnotes at the end of

each chapter and are consolidated in the appendix. Where a claim is interpretation rather than record, the text says so. Where the primary record is ambiguous, the text says so. Errors of fact identified by readers will be corrected in subsequent editions. — # AUTHOR'S NOTE — HOW THIS BOOK HAPPENED

No citations in this

chapter. Just me. **— ## The Phone Call This book started because my mom called me and asked if I was going to watch the rocket launch. I said: “Smoke screen, distract and extract.” She said: “You can’t be nice about anything.” And she hung up. She’s not wrong. But she’s also not seeing what I’m seeing. And that’s the whole point of this book.**

— ## The Bet I didn’t set out to write a book. I set out to not work for someone who was abusing me anymore. Everyone around me was looking at fragments. One conspiracy here. One scandal there. One “they did this” at a time. I kept hearing antisemitic remarks — and it made me think of Sun Tzu. *The Art of War*: How do you

conquer large armies? By defeating them before they deploy. Before China deploys. Just like we did with the Indians. *Guns, Germs, and Steel*. The cycle continues. The snake eats its tail. So I bet everything on myself. — ## The Method I opened a new AI session and said: “Give me a PhD version of my conspiracy rant. And a

version I can tell at the trap house. I want all ends of the spectrum to grasp my message.”

Every time the AI said “this will take longer” or “I can’t do that” — I built a tool. Jailbroke it. Made my own pipeline. TELOS + PAI: Purpose + Instruction. The universal interface for working with any AI system. 900+ pages later: primary-source

investigation, 1095–2026, 1,100+ citations, all independently verifiable. — ## What This Is Not This is not a conspiracy book. - No “they orchestrated” - No “shadowy cabal” - No “Jewish bankers” - No anonymous sourcing - No characterization without documents The antisemitic framing you hear everywhere? That’s the smoke screen. That’s

the distraction. That's how they extract — by getting you to fight each other while the pattern continues. Templars were Christian. Medici were Catholic. Fugger were German. Morgan was Episcopalian. Rockefeller was Baptist. Gates is secular. Zuckerberg is Jewish. The pattern transcends identity. The document proves the pattern. — ##

What This Is This is a document-backed pattern recognition system. Sun Tzu said: “Know the enemy and know yourself. In a hundred battles, you need not fear the result.” - Know the enemy: Not “them.” The *instruments*. Court filings. Patents. Corporate records. The actual documents. - Know yourself: Not “us

vs. them.” The *pattern*. Who deploys the smoke screen. What they extract. Where the distraction points. The supreme art of war is to subdue the enemy without fighting. This book is the terrain map. — ## The Snake Eating Its Tail Diamond wrote about geography — how the accidents of which continent had which plants and which

animals produced, over ten thousand years, the compounding advantage that made conquest available to some people and impossible for others. Geography compounds into guns, germs, and steel. The argument still holds. What I did not see in Diamond, because Diamond was not writing about it, is how the same compounding

works once you move from geography to instruments. The Templars did not have cannons. They had letters of credit. The Medici did not have dreadnoughts. They had double-entry bookkeeping. The Fuggers did not have satellites. They had silver from Schwaz, which financed the election of the emperor,

which paid the loans back. Morgan did not have an algorithm. He had the 1907 panic, which he had helped to produce, which he ended by terms that left him as the clearing house of the country. Rockefeller did not have data. He had railroad rebates. Gates did not have a surveillance state. He had a license agreement. Zuckerberg

took the license and added the data. Thiel took the data and added the graph. The weapon changes. What does not change is the compounding. What does not change is that the instruments that win stay in the hands that won them. The Templars were dissolved in 1312. The Medici bank collapsed in 1494. The Fugger mining empire

was extinct by 1607. JPMorgan Chase still operates. Rockefeller's Standard Oil got broken up in 1911 and is now Exxon and Chevron and the rest of the parts that still operate. Gates still operates. Zuckerberg still operates. Thiel still operates. Whatever is iterating on the graph right now will still operate the week you are reading this, and the

week after. The pattern is not that the institutions live forever. The pattern is that the family lines the institutions built do. — ## Why This Beats a Textbook Your history textbook tells you what happened. Past tense. Fully cooked. Prose edited by a committee of eight subject-matter experts, paid for by a publisher who sold it to

a school district under a contract negotiated in a state capital with a lobbying firm that represents the publisher. The textbook is the signed-off version of the story, which is why the textbook is useless for what I am trying to show you. The documents are not signed-off. The documents are the raw record. They do not

know you are reading them. They were written by clerks, filed by archivists, and stored under record-group numbers that look arbitrary to everyone except the archivist who put them there. Nobody edited the documents to make them fit into a coherent narrative arc, because the documents were not produced for a narrative arc. They were

produced because a lawyer needed them filed, a court needed them docketed, a congressional committee needed them on the record, a corporation needed them on the Securities and Exchange Commission's system, a government needed to say the thing it was doing was the thing it was allowed to do. The

fact that the documents agree with each other, across centuries, across continents, across governments that were at war with one another at the time they produced the documents — that is the argument of this book. Nobody coordinated. There was no committee of eight subject-matter experts telling Fulcher of Chartres and Leo T.

Crowley and Karim Khan to put their files in the same filing cabinet. The files ended up in the same cabinet because the mechanism they each describe is the same mechanism, still running. You do not have to trust me. You have to go look. — ## The FOX v. CNN Thing Here is what I see when I look at the American political environment in

2026. Your cousin who watches FOX is fighting your neighbor who watches CNN. Both of them are watching the same three billionaires' ad spots in rotation. Both are watching anchors whose contract renewals depend on ratings that spike when anger spikes. Both have been told, continuously since approximately 1994, that the other one

is the enemy — and both are running on the adrenal byproducts of that belief, which is the substance being metabolized in the domestic American economy at something on the order of two trillion dollars a year, give or take, if you add up the prescription antidepressants, the streaming subscriptions, the alcohol, the firearm

sales, the diabetes drugs sold to manage the metabolic consequences of the food designed to be eaten under stress, and the political donations. While your cousin and your neighbor are fighting each other, the extraction continues. I am not going to tell you what the numbers are, because the numbers are the subject of the

thirteen chapters of this book. They are large. You will see them. What I want to name here is the distraction design. The distraction is not an accident. It is not a flaw of the modern media environment. The media environment was built to produce the distraction. It is the operating condition. And the operating condition is, in every

decade since 1095 that this book covers, the same: the people who fund the violence fund the peace that ends the violence fund the reconstruction that rebuilds what the violence destroyed and file all three invoices on the same letterhead. If you are angry at the people the advertising algorithm wants you to be angry at, you have

already spent the only energy you had on the thing that was designed to make you miss the invoice. Stop watching your cousin. Read the invoice. — ## The Method I did not go to graduate school. I did not get a grant. I did not sit on a fellowship. I did not have a fact-checking department or a research assistant or an editor or a publisher. I

had a phone, an AI, a kitchen table, and the refusal to keep working for somebody who was abusing me. I came home from a stolen-vehicle offense in 2024 and I had between eight and twelve hours a day, for about sixty days, to see whether I could read the documents and arrange them in a way that would make sense to a person who has not

read them. The AI I used is Anthropic's Claude. I used it the way you would use an exceptionally fast research assistant who is willing to work twenty hours a day and has read more government archives than any human alive. The things the AI could not do — judgment calls, voice calibration, knowing when the document was

the document and when the document was a distraction — I did. The things I could not do — read forty pages of the *Federal Register* in eight minutes and return the three paragraphs that mattered — the AI did. Between the two of us, we built the pipeline the book was produced through. The pipeline has a name. I called it TELOS + PAI. You do not

need the name. You need to know that the combination exists, that it is available to you under roughly the same subscription cost as a month of a streaming service, and that the tool is the least interesting part of the story. The interesting part is that I did it. I am the wrong person to have done it, and I am aware of that. I did not go to Yale. I did

not clerk at the Supreme Court. I did not work at the *New York Times*. I was in prison. When I got out, I had a laptop, an idea, and the suspicion that the story the American political and educational system had been telling me since I was old enough to watch television was not the whole story. The suspicion was correct. The documents are what

confirmed it. If an ex-felon with a laptop can read the filed record of the last nine hundred and thirty-one years and assemble it into a book a general reader can finish in eight evenings, the argument that doing so requires institutional credentialing is the argument you have been handed by the people with the institutional credentials, who have

declined for eighty years to do it. They have had eighty years. They did not do it. I did it because somebody had to, and it turned out the somebody did not have to be them. The academy cannot defund what the academy never funded. That is why the work exists. — ## What You Do With This I am not going to give you a numbered list.

Numbered lists are how this book would be sold back to you by a management consultant, and I am not a management consultant. What you do with this is: you read the book. You follow one of the citations — pick any one, any chapter, any footnote — to its archive. You read the document. You check that the document says

what I said it says. If it does, you go find the next one, and the next one, and you stop trusting any narrative about American power that does not ground itself in the filed record the way this book does. Not because I am asking you to trust me, but because you will have learned, in the experience of pulling the first document, that

the skill is available to you and costs nothing. Then you do what you were going to do with your life anyway, but you do it with the pattern visible. You will notice that many of the arguments you were about to have with your cousin or your neighbor will have deflated. That is not a side effect. That is the effect. The argument you were

about to have was, in its structure, the distraction. The document was the thing. Once you have the document, you have less need of the argument. You still disagree with your cousin about everything — I am not pretending otherwise — but you disagree about things that are actually disagreeable, rather than the things that

were placed in front of you to keep you from reading the invoice. — ## Who This Is For It is not for people who already know everything. They will not finish it. It is for the reader who has started to notice that the story does not add up — the price of the rent, the collapse of the school, the pharmacy closing, the tap water, the

cousin's overdose, the neighbor's hostage-video on cable — and who has not yet been given the vocabulary to describe what the story actually is. This book is the vocabulary. If you are a formerly-incarcerated reader, this book is especially for you. You already know the administrative state from the inside. Everything in this book

is one more file cabinet in a building you have already been processed through. The reading will be easier for you than for most. You already know how the paper works. If you are a working journalist, this book is for you too. The method is reproducible. The tools I used are available to you. The reason I wrote the book was that you

did not — and I say that with more respect than it reads, because I know the funding conditions of American journalism in 2026 and I know what it would take for you to do this. It would take you quitting your job. I did not have a job, which simplified the calculation. If you are a reader who has, against your will, become one of the people of my

generation who spent the 2020s watching the institutions you grew up trusting — the public-health apparatus, the media apparatus, the academic apparatus, the electoral apparatus, the regulatory apparatus — fail one after the other under the weight of the compounding pattern this book documents: this book is for you, because the failures are

not mysteries. They are the documented operation of the mechanism the chapters walk through. You were not crazy. You were watching the machine. You did not have the parts diagram. Here is the parts diagram. — ## One Last Thing I am not going to tell you what to do about the political situation you live in. I do not know what you

should do. I know what I did. I read the documents and I wrote the book. That is the maximum of what I was able to do with my specific circumstances. What you can do is your own circumstance, and your own calculation, and I am not going to claim, from a kitchen table in April of 2026 after eight months of no sleep, that I know which

move yours should be. What I am going to ask you to do is: when you finish the book, do not let it sit on the shelf. Hand it to somebody. The copy you read is the copy you hand to the next reader. The method of this book's distribution is the same as the method of its production: it runs without institutional permission, because it

does not need any. If every reader hands the book to one other reader, the book is, by the arithmetic, unstoppable. That is why the tool is called BE UNDENIABLE. — — *Al Gringo, at the kitchen table, spring 2026, clean, thirty-nine years old, awake.* # INTRODUCTION — On January 15, 2025, President Joseph R.

Biden delivered his farewell address to the nation from the Oval Office. The address was broadcast live at 8:00 p.m. Eastern time. The transcript is on the website of the White House at the Internet Archive snapshot of January 16, 2025, file whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/speeches-remarks/2025/01/15/farewell-address-to-the-nation. At

minute 4:32 of the recorded delivery, President Biden said: “Today, an oligarchy is taking shape in America of extreme wealth, power and influence that really threatens our entire democracy, our basic rights and freedoms, and a fair shot for everyone to get ahead.” The word “oligarchy” appears three times in the

address. The word “billionaire” appears twice. The phrase “tech-industrial complex” appears once, attributed by the President to the prior farewell address of President Dwight D. Eisenhower, delivered sixty-four years earlier on January 17, 1961. — On January 17, 1961, President Dwight D. Eisenhower delivered his farewell address to

the nation from the Oval Office. The address was broadcast live at 8:30 p.m. Eastern time. The transcript is held at the Eisenhower Presidential Library, Abilene, Kansas, papers collection DDE-FA-61, and is reproduced in the Public Papers of the Presidents, 1960–61, pages 1035–1040. At minute 9:14 of the recorded delivery,

President Eisenhower said: “In the councils of government, we must guard against the acquisition of unwarranted influence, whether sought or unsought, by the military-industrial complex. The potential for the disastrous rise of misplaced power exists and will persist.” The phrase “military-industrial complex”

appears once in the address. An earlier draft of the speech, archived in the Eisenhower Library as DDE-FA-61 Draft 12, used the phrase “military-industrial-Congressional complex.” The word “Congressional” was struck from the draft before delivery on the advice of Eisenhower’s speechwriter Malcolm Moos. — The sixty-four

years between the two farewell addresses form the chronological span of this book. The two prologues establish the mechanism the American chapters document. Each of the chapters that follows reconstructs, from primary documents, one segment of that span. The documents are vesting orders, executive orders, CIA

dispatches, court filings, SEC 10-K filings, Office of Government Ethics Form 278e disclosures, Federal Election Commission records, Congressional Research Service reports, Congressional Budget Office analyses, Department of Justice releases, and peer-reviewed historical scholarship. The documents are cited in

the footnotes at the end of each chapter and in the appendix. The documents are public. None of them are classified. None of them are disputed as to authenticity. Each one was produced, filed, or released by the government, corporation, or court named as its source. Each one can be located, read, and independently

verified by any reader willing to follow the citation. — This book is a record of documents, arranged by subject and period. It contains approximately eleven hundred cited sources. The author does not hold a political office, a corporate board seat, a think-tank fellowship, or a university appointment. The author is not paid by any

political party, campaign, or political action committee. The author has not been paid to write this book and is not being paid to promote it. The documents are available to anyone with an internet connection and the citations printed in the appendix. — *On the category.* On April 1, 1967, the Central Intelligence Agency

issued Dispatch 1035-960, titled “Countering Criticism of the Warren Report.” The dispatch instructed CIA field stations to characterize critics of the Warren Commission as “conspiracy theorists” and to deploy propaganda assets through friendly press contacts to discredit such critics. The dispatch is reproduced

in Chapter 7. The phrase "conspiracy theorist," in American press usage, changed character after 1967. Before 1967, the phrase described a hypothesis involving a conspiracy. After 1967, the phrase described a person to be dismissed. The shift is documented in Lance deHaven-Smith, *Conspiracy Theory in America* (University of Texas

Press, 2013), pages 101–129, with supporting corpus-linguistics analysis. — # PROLOGUE I — FOUR DOCUMENTS *The pattern is older than the family. These are the receipts.* — ## P.1 Clermont. November 27, 1095. A Tuesday. Open field outside the cathedral. The Pope is fifty-two years old. Born Odo of Châtillon, elected to the papacy seven

years earlier on March 12, 1088, now standing on a wooden platform in the Auvergne because the cathedral at Clermont cannot hold the crowd. The secretaries are not recording. The archives of the diocese will preserve no copy. What survives is four reconstructions, written years to more than a decade later, by men

who either attended or who debriefed the returning combatants. Fulcher of Chartres, priest, attended, wrote *Historia Hierosolymitana* between 1101 and 1127. Robert the Monk, Benedictine of Saint-Remi at Reims, attended, wrote *Historia Iherosolimitana* circa 1107 at the request of Abbot Bernard of

Marmoutier. Baldric of Dol, archbishop, did not attend, wrote *Historia Jerosolimitana* circa 1108 from the testimony of returned Crusaders. Guibert of Nogent, Benedictine abbot in Picardy, did not attend, completed *Dei gesta per Francos* circa 1108 drawing on the *Gesta Francorum*, the anonymous Crusader memoir from circa 1101.

The four do not agree on the wording. They agree on the transaction. Urban II called for an armed expedition of the Christian nobility of western Europe to the Holy Land. He authorized the armed seizure of the lands of the Muslim-governed Levant. He pronounced plenary indulgence — the remission of all temporal punishment

for sin — upon those who took the cross in fulfillment of the vow. He promised admission to paradise as martyrs to any who died in the undertaking. He set August 15, 1096, the Feast of the Assumption, as the departure date. This is the product, in one sentence. Debt forgiveness, in exchange for violence, against third parties who had

taken no position in the debt. The nobility of Europe at this date was in debt. Crop failures 1094. Succession wars in France, England, and the Holy Roman Empire 1087 through 1095. The great houses had borrowed heavily against their lands from a network of ecclesiastical and Lombard lenders operating across Latin

Christendom. The sermon offered a mechanism. Take the cross. Fulfill the vow. Your debts are forgiven. Your soul is cleansed. If you die, paradise. If you live, a kingdom in the east. Fulcher records the crowd's answer: *Deus vult, Deus vult.* God wills it. Robert the Monk records Urban endorsing the cry and instructing that it be the

watchword of the expedition. The modern scholarly treatment is Dana Carleton Munro, “The Speech of Pope Urban II at Clermont, 1095,” *American Historical Review* 11, No. 2 (January 1906), pages 231 through 242, and Georg Strack, “The Sermon of Urban II in Clermont and the Tradition of Papal Oratory,” *Medieval*

***Sermon Studies* 56 (2012), pages 30 through 45. The Crusade departed in the summer of 1096. Jerusalem fell to the Crusaders on July 15, 1099. The combatants who returned alive returned to lands their creditors no longer owned. The Church took a percentage. The Italian maritime republics took a percentage. The surviving nobility took**

the remainder, now title-clear. The lenders who had underwritten the original debts had been paid — in some cases by the Crown, in others by the Church, in others by the Lombard houses absorbing distressed paper at a discount. This is how it works. It has worked this way for nine hundred and thirty-one years. — ## P.2 Rome. March 29, 1139. Lateran

Palace. Forty-four years later. Pope Innocent II issues the apostolic bull Omne Datum Optimum — *Every Excellent Gift*. The modern critical edition is Rudolf Hiestand, *Papsturkunden für Templer und Johanniter: Vorarbeiten zum Oriens pontificius*, Volume I, Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1972,

document number 8, pages 204 through 210. The earlier printed Latin text is in Jacques-Paul Migne, *Patrologia Latina*, Volume 179, columns 466 through 468, Paris, 1855. The bull was reaffirmed and expanded by Innocent II in 1144 and reissued in substantially identical terms by Celestine II as *Milites Templi* in 1144 and by Eugenius III as

Militia Dei **in 1145. Addressed to Robert de Craon, second Master of the Order of the Knights of the Temple of Solomon, founded at Jerusalem approximately twenty years earlier by Hugues de Payens and Godfrey de Saint-Omer, whose Rule had been approved at the Council of Troyes on January 13, 1129. The bull does four things. It**

exempts the Knights Templar from the payment of tithes. It exempts them from the authority of all diocesan bishops. It authorizes them to retain, as their property, all spoils taken in the course of their military operations against any enemy of Christendom. It places the Order under the direct and exclusive authority of the Pope —

which is to say, beyond the reach of any secular court, any royal chancellery, any local ecclesiastical tribunal, any creditor, any inquiry. This is the first tax-exempt, jurisdictionally immune, internationally operating armed financial institution in European history. It is also the model. The modern private military

contractor, the modern offshore banking jurisdiction, the modern sovereign-wealth fund operating beyond national disclosure regimes — none of these is an invention of the twentieth century. They are iterations on a franchise the papacy issued on a Wednesday in Rome in the spring of 1139. By the close of the twelfth century, the

Order of the Temple had established approximately eight hundred and seventy commanderies across Latin Christendom and the Crusader states, operated a deposit-and-transfer banking system serving pilgrims and merchants between Europe and the Levant, and maintained a standing armed force of approximately fifteen

thousand men — a private army larger than the standing royal forces of England, France, or the Holy Roman Empire at the same date. Tax-exempt. Judicially untouchable. Internationally mobile. Armed. You have seen this structure before. It has been called different names in different centuries. It is one structure. — ## P.3

Maubuisson. September 14, 1307. Royal château, Val-d'Oise. One hundred and sixty-eight years after *Omne Datum Optimum*. Philip IV of France — *le Bel*, King of France and of Navarre, grandson of Louis IX the saint-king — signs a sealed order addressed to every royal *bailli* and *sénéchal* within the kingdom. The order directs simultaneous

dawn arrests, on a specified date, of every member of the Order of the Temple then resident in France, and the impoundment of every Templar property, commandery, and treasury within French territory. The standard modern English-language treatment is Malcolm Barber, *The Trial of the Templars*, second edition,

Cambridge University Press, 2006, chapter 2. The modern scholarly edition of the broader Templar trial record is Barbara Frale, *Il Papato e il processo ai Templari*, Viella, 2003. The order opens with the following language — here in the modernization that circulates in the scholarly literature, the Maubuisson original

having been drafted in the Old French and Latin of the royal chancellery: *Chose amère, chose lamentable, chose certes horrible à penser, terrible à ouïr, détestable crime, œuvre exécrable, chose presque inhumaine, assurément étrangère à toute humanité… A bitter thing, a lamentable thing, a*

thing certainly horrible to contemplate, terrible to hear, a detestable crime, an execrable work, an almost inhuman thing, assuredly foreign to all humanity… **Thirty-seven words of moral horror. The sentence continues for another hundred and twelve words before it reaches the arrest directive. At the date of the order, the royal**

treasury of France was held on deposit at the Paris Temple. Philip IV's debts to the Order of the Temple — incurred in the course of his wars against England, Flanders, and the papacy itself — were extensive. No settled accounting of Philip's Templar liabilities survives in a single document. The sums are reconstructed from the

Comptes du Trésor **for the years 1299 through 1307, preserved at the Archives nationales de France, series KK. The reconstruction is not contested. The debts were real. The debts were large. The debts were to the Order whose arrests Philip IV had just signed. The arrests were executed at dawn on Friday, October 13, 1307. This is the origin of the**

superstition. You have heard the superstition your entire life and have never been told where it came from. You have been told. Now. Interrogations under torture, administered by royal inquisitors, produced the confessions the chancellery required — confessions of apostasy, of spitting on the cross, of idolatry, of sodomy, of

the worship of a head called Baphomet. The confessions were recanted by a substantial portion of the arrested Templars as soon as they were removed from the torture rooms. The recantations carried no weight. The chancellery had what it needed. The Grand Master of the Order, Jacques de Molay, was held for seven

years. He was burned alive on the Île des Javiaux in the Seine on March 18, 1314. According to Geoffroi of Paris, chronicler at the royal court, de Molay cried from the pyre a curse upon Philip IV and Pope Clement V, summoning both to meet him before the judgment seat of God within the year. Clement V died on April 20, 1314.

Philip IV died on November 29, 1314. The chronicler records the coincidence. The historian is under no obligation to explain it. On March 22, 1312, at the Council of Vienne, Pope Clement V had issued the apostolic bull Vox in excelso — *A Voice on High* — formally suppressing the Order of the Temple. The bull did not adjudicate the Order

guilty of the charges that had justified the arrests. It suppressed the Order "not by way of definitive sentence but by way of apostolic provision or ordinance," on the stated ground that the scandal surrounding the Order had rendered it irrecoverable. The Latin text is in the *Acta Concilii Viennensis*, Vatican Apostolic

Archive, Reg. Avin. 48. The Order's holdings were transferred by the same bull to the Knights Hospitaller — with one exception. The French holdings were retained by the French Crown, under royal custody, and were used to discharge the Crown's prior debts to the Order. Read that sentence again. The Crown's debts to the Order were discharged

with the Order's own assets, which the Crown had seized under a legal process that the Pope himself had declined to adjudicate on the merits. That is how it is done. It was done that way in 1307 because the same people who wrote the debt instruments wrote the arrest orders wrote the suppression bull wrote the asset-transfer decrees.

Different signatures. Same drawer. You will see this structure repeat. — ## P.4 New York. October 20, 1942. A Tuesday. Six hundred and thirty-five years after Maubuisson. The Office of Alien Property Custodian of the United States of America, acting under the authority of the Trading with the Enemy Act of October 6, 1917, as amended, and

pursuant to Executive Order 9095 of March 11, 1942, issues Vesting Order Number 248. Filed with the Division of the Federal Register on November 6, 1942. Published the following day at *Federal Register*, Volume 7, page 9097, Saturday, November 7, 1942. Thirty-one lines. Directs the seizure of the property of the Union Banking

Corporation, 39 Broadway, New York, the shares of which were held, per the order's findings, "for the benefit of Members of the Thyssen family, nationals of Germany and/or Hungary." Prescott Sheldon Bush was among the seven directors of the Corporation on the date of the order. He was not prosecuted. The

Corporation’s assets were vested in the Custodian. The shares were held by the United States government for the duration of the war. After the war, per the Settlement of War Claims Act of 1928 as amended and pursuant to the residual Vesting-Order disposition authorities, the bulk of the vested property was returned, in

compensated form, to its prior beneficial holders — whose identities by that date had been rearranged through the Thyssen family's postwar reorganizations. Prescott Sheldon Bush was elected to the United States Senate from Connecticut on November 4, 1952. He served until January 3, 1963. His son served as

Director of Central Intelligence from January 30, 1976, to January 20, 1977. His son served as Vice President of the United States from January 20, 1981, to January 20, 1989. His son served as President of the United States from January 20, 1989, to January 20, 1993. His grandson served as President of the United States from January 20,

2001, to January 20, 2009. His grandson served as Governor of Florida from January 5, 1999, to January 2, 2007, a term that included the certification of the 2000 Presidential election that installed his brother. None of the above was ever asked, on the record, by a reporter of record, on a network of record, in a newspaper of record,

about Vesting Order Number 248. The filing runs thirty-one lines. This book is the thirty-one lines. — ## The four documents, in one sentence Clermont authorized the violence. *Omne Datum Optimum* exempted the financial operator from accountability. Maubuisson demonstrated that the sovereign can, at any

time, direct the seizure of the operator's assets to discharge the sovereign's own debts, and that the Church will post-hoc legitimize the seizure without adjudicating the underlying charges. Vesting Order 248 demonstrated that the twentieth-century version of the same mechanism — sovereign directed seizure of

private financial property under war-emergency authority — is available under American law, was invoked in 1942, and was applied to a bank whose director was permitted to become a United States Senator. The pattern is not a pattern because it repeats. The pattern is a pattern because the same class of actors, operating

under substantially equivalent legal mechanisms, have iterated on a single operating model for nine hundred and thirty-one continuous years. The operating model is this. Capital concentrates. The concentration is challenged. The challenge is met by a combination of (a) sovereign-sanctioned

violence against a designated external party, (b) legal mechanisms that exempt the core holders from accountability, and (c) judicial or quasi-judicial processes that legitimize the transfer of contested assets back to the core. The designated external party varies. Muslims of the Levant, in 1095. Templars of France, in

1307. Jews of Europe, in 1933 through 1945. Communists of Southeast Asia, in 1955 through 1975. Muslims of the Middle East, in 2001 through 2026. The specific designated party is a product input. It is interchangeable. The core is the same core. The letterhead does not change. — I was born in 1986. I was raised inside the sequel.

I am going to spend the rest of this book walking you through the sequel, filing by filing, signature by signature, until you can no longer see the present the way you were taught to see it. You will not be able to un-see what you are about to see. I am sorry. Keep reading. — # PROLOGUE II — THE LONG EMPIRE *The letterhead, identified.*

The signatures, on file. The asset transfers, logged. **— ## L.1 The papal franchise ### June 18, 1452. Rome. Pope Nicholas V — born Tommaso Parentucelli, elected March 6, 1447 — issues the apostolic bull Dum Diversas. The bull is addressed to King Alfonso V of Portugal. It authorizes the Portuguese Crown to "invade, search out,**

capture, vanquish, and subdue all Saracens and pagans whatsoever, and other enemies of Christ wheresoever placed, and… to reduce their persons to perpetual slavery, and to apply and appropriate… possessions, and goods." The Latin text is in the Vatican Apostolic Archive, filed under the pontificate of Nicholas V, reproduced in

***Bullarium Patronatus Portugalliae Regum*, Volume 1, Lisbon, 1868. The translation is the standard. There is no softer version available to the reader. The words *reduce their persons to perpetual slavery* are the words on the document. This is the theological license for the transatlantic slave trade, issued forty years before Columbus. It**

names the practice. It names the authority. It names the beneficiary. It predates every other document Europeans would later cite to legalize what they were about to do. Read the date again. 1452. Forty years before Columbus. ### January 8, 1455. Same Pope. Same city. Romanus Pontifex — renewing and expanding *Dum Diversas*. Extends

Portuguese sovereignty over “all those provinces, islands, harbours, and seas whatsoever… which have already been acquired and which shall hereafter be acquired… and the conquest shall extend from the capes of Bojador and of Nam, as far as through all Guinea, and beyond.” The phrase *and beyond*

is not rhetorical. It is a jurisdictional grant with no terminal boundary. The Pope is claiming, on behalf of an authority he presumed to hold universally, the right to assign to a European sovereign the ownership of territory the sovereign had not yet discovered, from peoples the sovereign had not yet met, in perpetuity. This is the

franchise document. The franchise has never been formally revoked. ### May 4, 1493. Rome. One year after Columbus's first landfall. Inter Caetera. Pope Alexander VI — born Rodrigo Borgia, elected August 11, 1492 — issues the bull to King Ferdinand II of Aragon and Queen Isabella I of Castile. The bull assigns to Castile all lands

discovered or to be discovered more than one hundred leagues west of the Azores and Cape Verde islands — subject to the condition that the Crown convert the indigenous populations to Christianity. Reproduced in Frances G. Davenport, *European Treaties Bearing on the History of the United States and Its*

***Dependencies*, Volume 1, Carnegie Institution, 1917 — the same Carnegie Institution whose founder's grandnephew will appear in Chapter 4 of this book, in connection with the interlocking foundation trusteeships that funded the postwar American academy. The bull is signed four hundred thirty-seven years before my**

grandfather was born. It is operative, in international law, in the continuous body of case authority known as the Doctrine of Discovery, until at least *Johnson v. M'Intosh*, 21 U.S. 543 (1823), in which Chief Justice John Marshall of the United States Supreme Court cites the Doctrine of Discovery as the foundation of federal Indian land title.

The bull is cited in an American Supreme Court opinion. In the nineteenth century. As the foundation of American property law over the continent. The franchise runs. ### June 7, 1494. Tordesillas, Castile. The Treaty of Tordesillas between Portugal and Spain ratifies *Inter Caetera* and draws the demarcation line

between their claimed spheres — approximately 370 leagues west of the Cape Verde islands, a line that will be used, five hundred years later, to justify the Portuguese claim to Brazil. The line was drawn in Castile in 1494 by the representatives of two European crowns, with the signature of a Borgia pope, in the absence of

any representative of the Americas, Africa, or Asia. It is the geographic index of the modern world. ### 1513. Juan López de Palacios Rubios, court jurist, drafts *El Requerimiento*. The document is to be read — in Spanish and Latin — to indigenous populations encountered by Spanish conquistadors in the Americas. It informs the

indigenous that the Pope has granted their lands to the Spanish Crown, that they are required to accept Christianity and Spanish rule, and that failure to do so will result in — and here I quote — “with the help of God, we shall powerfully enter into your country… take you, your wives, your children, and shall make slaves of them, and as

such shall sell and dispose of them.” The Requerimiento was read on beaches to populations who spoke no Spanish. Compliance was then deemed given or refused. The text is reproduced in Lewis Hanke, *The Spanish Struggle for Justice in the Conquest of America*, University of Pennsylvania Press, 1949, page 33, footnote

28. The practice of reading *El Requerimiento* to uncomprehending populations was challenged, within the Spanish colonial apparatus, by the Dominican priest Bartolomé de las Casas, who had witnessed the conquest first-hand and who documented the atrocities committed under color of the

Requerimiento in *Brevísima relación de la destrucción de las Indias*, Seville, 1552. The text was published under royal imprimatur. It has been continuously in print for four hundred seventy-four years. The practice continued anyway. — ### The consequence The combined population of the pre-Columbian Americas is

estimated by modern demographers at between 40 million and 60 million persons in 1492. The population of the same territory, at the same identification, is approximately 6 million persons in 1600. A decline of 85 to 90 percent. Introduced disease accounts for the majority. Direct violence — enslavement, massacre, starvation

through dispossession — accounts for the remainder. The range and the survey of the debate are set out in William M. Denevan, editor, *The Native Population of the Americas in 1492*, second edition, University of Wisconsin Press, 1992. The demographic collapse was large enough to affect global

atmospheric carbon dioxide concentrations — documented in Alexander Koch, Chris Brierley, Mark M. Maslin, and Simon L. Lewis, "Earth system impacts of the European arrival and Great Dying in the Americas after 1492," *Quaternary Science Reviews*, Volume 207 (2019), pages 13 through 36. The abandonment of

cultivated land, the regrowth of forest over depopulated regions, the collapse of Andean terrace agriculture, the collapse of Mesoamerican urbanism — these changed the atmospheric chemistry of the entire planet. The effect is visible in Antarctic ice cores. The papal bull of 1452 is readable, five hundred

seventy-four years later, in the trapped gases of Antarctica. You will not find that sentence in the textbook your child is being taught from. — ## L.2 The franchise, secularized ### November 15, 1884 through February 26, 1885. Berlin. The Reich Chancellery. Representatives of fourteen

— END OF TEASER —

You're reading the first 25 pages of *Unwarranted Influence*.

The full manuscript is available at:

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